



gate candidates for free, charging only for IVF and hospital fees, refuses to term it "rent a womb", calling it "donating a womb" instead. "There's a powerful emotional angle to it which gets buried when it is described in the language of economics. I don't simply facilitate surrogacy, but also play the role of a psychiatrist," she insists. In many cases, the surrogate mother becomes so attached to the child that she forgets it is not hers genetically. Patel and her husband Hitesh, an orthopaedic surgeon, handle the psychological

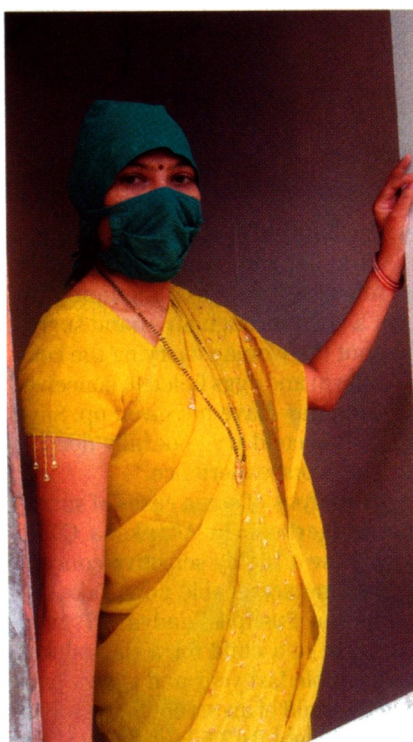
nancy an absolute secret. Her three children are under the impression that she has gone to Israel to work as a nurse on a year's contract. But the fact is, she is living in a flat in Anand where Regina, with Patel's help, is taking care of seven others who have taken up surrogacy in secret. Says Jagruti, "With the Rs 2.5 lakh that I will get, I will first clear a loan of Rs 1 lakh that my husband had taken and also buy a new CNG autorickshaw for him."

The story of Jasmine Pravin Christian, 42, the oldest among the surrogate mothers in Anand, is even more moving. Her husband is a drunkard and one of her daughters, who suffers from mental disability, needs immediate treatment. On a nurse's advice, Jasmine is carrying the child of an Indian couple based in Dubai. "I needed Rs 1.5 lakh for my daughter's treatment," she says. Almost all these women come from the deprived sections of society, mostly Christians and the lower classes amongst the Hindus. Of the two Muslim women in Anand who are now pregnant, one will deliver for a foreign-based Muslim couple.

An attempt on the part of the poor to earn quick money is one of the main factors responsible for this phenomenon, but it could not have been possible without the awareness spread by Patel, who has tried to lend a human touch to a concept that is otherwise based on mere economic give-and-take. The doctor, who arranges surro-

"I will repay my husband's loan of Rs 1 lakh and buy him a CNG autorickshaw."

JAGRUTI RATHOD, SURROGATE MOTHER



aspect of such cases. Some devout Hindu couples request the surrogate mother to read verses from the Gita in the belief that it will have a positive effect on the development of their child in her womb. In all this, the Patels are the crucial link. Another responsibility is to ensure that the money a surrogate receives is properly spent by her and not blown away by her husband. For this, the duo counsels the pregnant surrogate. Admits Patel, "The emotional pressure is too much to bear at times."

In a recent case, a couple was so grateful to the surrogate mother for giving birth to their baby that they deposited a sum of Rs 50,000 in fixed deposits in the name of each of her children. Another beneficiary couple from Hyderabad keep a picture of the surrogate mother in their puja room. The same sentiment is echoed by Dipti, 29, and Rajesh Pandya, 40, of the UK, who are now expecting their first child through a surrogate. When Dipti came to Anand to finalise their candidate, she wept uncontrollably recalling how badly she was treated just because she was 'barren'. True to its name, Anand has brought joy to many childless couples. Even as Patel says it is a win-win situation for the couple as well as for the poor surrogate mother, the rather unorthodox practice banned in many western countries and regulated strictly by law in others, continues to pose a moral question. ■